Address at the Brandenburg Gate — ‘Tear Down This Wall’

President Ronald Reagan · West Berlin · June 12, 1987

Source: Ronald Reagan, Remarks at the Brandenburg Gate, West Berlin (June 12, 1987), text via The American Presidency Project, UC Santa Barbara. Public domain.

Standing before the Berlin Wall on the 750th anniversary of the city, Reagan called on Soviet General Secretary Mikhail Gorbachev — then pursuing glasnost and perestroika — to tear it down. State Department officials had repeatedly tried to remove the line from the speech, worried it would derail diplomacy. Reagan insisted on keeping it. The Wall fell two and a half years later (November 9, 1989); the Soviet Union dissolved in December 1991.

Connect: The Cold War lasted from ~1945 (Class 52) to 1991 — 45+ years. Identify the presidency (or event) you think most contributed to its end, and defend your choice.

Key Passages

On freedom

> We hear much from Moscow about a new policy of reform and openness. Some political prisoners have been released. … Are these the beginnings of profound changes in the Soviet state? Or are they token gestures, intended to raise false hopes in the West, or to strengthen the Soviet system without changing it? We welcome change and openness; for we believe that freedom and security go together, that the advance of human liberty can only strengthen the cause of world peace.

The famous line

> General Secretary Gorbachev, if you seek peace, if you seek prosperity for the Soviet Union and Eastern Europe, if you seek liberalization: Come here to this gate! Mr. Gorbachev, open this gate! Mr. Gorbachev, tear down this wall!

Because we remained strong

> Because we remained strong, the Soviets came back to the table. And because we remained strong, today we have within reach the possibility, not merely of limiting the growth of arms, but of eliminating, for the first time, an entire class of nuclear weapons from the face of the Earth.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The late Cold War: Gorbachev's reforms (glasnost, perestroika), Reagan's military buildup, and arms-control talks, with Berlin still divided by the Wall.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	West Berliners in the crowd, Mikhail Gorbachev and Soviet leaders, East Berliners and Eastern Europeans, and the American public.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Ronald Reagan, a conservative, anticommunist president who believed in confronting the Soviet Union and promoting democratic freedom.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Complexity (1 pt): Argue BOTH that Reagan's policies hastened the Cold War's end AND that internal Soviet decisions were the more important cause.
2. Why did Reagan's State Department want to cut the 'tear down this wall' line?
3. Identify TWO other events between 1987 and 1991 that ended the Cold War.